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UNCOVERING ARCHIVAL SILENCES THROUGH PHOTOGRAPHS AND LISTENING

Envisioning archives as a democratic space

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On 12 May 1974, 20-year-old engineering student Lito Ocampo was arrested in a military round-up in Pangasinan. Together with the other detainees, he endured intimidation and was imprisoned for five years. Prior to Lito's arrest, the late President Ferdinand Marcos signed Proclamation No. 1081 that officially placed the entire Philippines under martial law on 21 September 1972. Marcos assumed all powers of government,[1] and authorised the military to arrest personalities including journalists, political activists and militant students who were explicitly against his administration.[2] A few years later when Lito was already discharged from prison, he met Rodolfo Benosa in a military camp in Bicutan. Rodolfo, a 33-year-old factory worker and a labour union leader, was arrested in his house in San Jose del Monte, Bulacan, in 1982. At the time of his arrest, torture and imprisonment, martial law was already suspended but Marcos continued to hold absolute authority over the country.

Marcos repudiated allegations of human rights violations committed under his command, and made subversion, rebellion, sedition and other political crimes capital offences in the midst of the increasing anti-Marcos sentiments.[3] Civil liberties were evidently missing and so were adequate evidence and accounts of what was going on behind the pompous drapes of Marcos' *Bagong Lipunan* or New Society. There was widespread closure of media outlets, strict control of newspapers, magazines and student publications, and military raids on private residences, printing presses, universities and even libraries.[4] In this perilous situation, stories of people like Lito and Rodolfo were expectedly absent in the mainstream media – and creating and keeping any documentation that was deemed subversive by the government would have put someone's life in danger at that time. However, Lito clandestinely took photographs of the detainees inside the prison – including Rodolfo. Lito used photographs as evidence that would stand for the victims and their family. His photographs are just a few slivers of the painful realities of this regime, and there

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are a great deal of missing records of stories and experiences of people during this era – especially those in the margins. The absence of democracy created silences not only in the lives and consciousness of the people who lived through this time, but more in what would be committed to the collective memory and future perceptions regarding this period. The shift of government and political structures has also caused inexorable silences, as well as the acts of memorialisation wherein not all voices are loud enough to be heard and recognised – and not all silences are the same.

Marcos regime and its silences

As in all societies that experienced authoritarian rule, the Marcos regime has multiple sides and stories, consequently it will not have a singular representation and definite end. The historic EDSA People Power Revolution in 1986 may have publicly ended the Marcos regime and became the link to the transitionary democratic government led by Corazon Aquino, but assembling the parts of the previous regime's memory puzzle is still ongoing. There are and will always be missing parts or silences that need to be acknowledged and appropriately addressed. The silences of the Marcos era have come from the regime itself, the succeeding governments that bid to deal with the past violations and the various acts of commemoration that attempt to form the official memory and narratives. In dealing with contested pasts, archivists are urged to embrace their power to interpret records and shape collective memory for the 'good of mankind'.[5] This memory work is more than building monuments to the past, but is a commitment to democracy and a performance of human rights. Human rights archival records are essential for historical accountability as post-authoritarian governments confront past crimes and end impunity.[6] The collective and organised effort to address these silences is likewise an act of raising awareness among citizens of their freedom and rights that they must responsibly exercise, value and protect.

Before the declaration of martial law in 1972, the Philippine press was extensively known as one of the freest in Asia.[7] Thus, the termination of a core foundation of democracy was regarded as a tragedy by those who supported and respected freedom.[8] Marcos justified martial law as his constitutional response to the 'state of anarchy and lawlessness, chaos and disorder, turmoil and destruction of a magnitude equivalent to an actual war between the forces of our duly constituted government and the New People's Army and their satellite organizations', and to the disturbances 'resulting from the unsettled conflict between certain elements of the Christian and Muslim population of Mindanao and Sulu'.[9] The Filipinos, especially the upper and middle-class, initially accepted and tolerated the first years of martial rule for its supposed peace and order, and political and economic reforms.[10] But this 'constitutional' response to social and political unrest left the country's economy in a shambles with billions of dollars of foreign debts, the nation's wealth plundered and thousands of human rights abuses.[11] Under the Marcos regime between 1972 and 1985, 70,000 people were incarcerated, 35,000 were tortured, 3257 were killed, 737

disappeared – and around 2520 or 77 percent of all victims were 'salvaged'.[12] The word 'salvage' or 'salvaged' started to have additional meaning under the regime. Its meaning changed from rescue to bodies that were 'tortured, mutilated, and dumped on a roadside for public display' turning this intimidating act into a 'theater state of terror'.[13]

In this time of fear and uncertainty, words about military abuses and people suddenly disappearing were heard through the grapevine. Without seeing and hearing evidence during this precarious state, the Filipinos conjured in their minds the images of this regime. These fleeting images may be deemed as missing or imagined records, which according to Anne Gilliland and Michelle Caswell, could help counteract the dominant power and act as symbols of the people's shared grief and hope.[14] With the death of Marcos in 1989, the victims and survivors like Lito and Rodolfo lost their chance to hear the dictator's statement – or if there would be any expression of remorse and apology from his end. The testimony that could have at least set historical facts straight for the present and future generations seemed to have died with him. Aside from the missing physical evidence of the regime due to repressive protocols, Marcos' would-be testimony constitutes another form of silence of this era that has an 'imaginary agency to settle competing versions of history'.[15] These missing records of the regime would have been useful in facilitating collective healing and possible reconciliation between the perpetrators and victims. However, as the living family members of Marcos have regained their political positions and never admitted their past wrongdoings,[16] transitional justice in the country has also remained elusive. The transition from dictatorship to democracy likewise caused particular silences especially to the victims.

After more than four decades, no transgressor was punished and the Philippines is one of the few countries that did not complete the truth commission report.[17] The investigation and recovery of the ill-gotten wealth of the Marcos family and their cronies has not been completely successful.[18] The reparations for the victims were also delayed.[19] With these issues encroaching the present, Randolf David argues that, 'the termination of the dictatorship was never a clean break. There are discontinuities as well as continuities: some old faces in new roles, some new faces in an unchanged bureaucracy'.[20] While many have continued their struggle for justice and healing, many victims are now voiceless – old, sickly, and without a stable source of livelihood.[21] Democracy was reinstated but the nation's difficult past besieged by social inequalities continues to haunt the Filipinos.

Another form of silence can be found in the gaps of memory sites as well as the narratives and discussions they evoke. The post-dictatorship years have seen different memorialisation including the publication of books reporting incarceration, lives and struggles of political leaders and details of stories of volunteerism during and after the era of terror.[22] But the remembrance of the Marcos regime is not only concentrated on the anti-Marcos narratives. Different commemorative sites were also built in Marcos' hometown in Ilocos Norte and there are yearly festivities to celebrate his birthday.[23] His preserved remains displayed in his mausoleum for two decades were secretly buried at the *Libingan ng mga Bayani* or Heroes Cemetery on

18 November 2016. Earlier that year, the late dictator's son and namesake, Ferdinand 'Bongbong' Marcos, Jr, ran for the second-highest position of the executive branch of the Philippine government. As if on cue, these two events ignited nostalgia and debates especially in social media. The tension arising from the opposing recollections and views shows the great divide in the public opinion and understanding of the Marcos era. The dominant narratives in national imaginaries are mostly centred on Marcos and the EDSA People Power Revolution that ended his rule.[24] It can be seen here that the manipulation of official memory rests on the hands of the powerful, with sufficient agency and voices loud enough to be heard. Whereas, those in the margins 'remain marginalized; they continue to live on the outskirts, on the peripheries, on the fringes of power'.[25]

With these observed silences, I searched for materials for my doctoral project on collective and individual memories of the Marcos regime. In early 2016, I was introduced to Lito by another photojournalist. Lito showed me some photographs he took in the 1980s as part of his human rights work and advocacy. He used photography as an instrument to counter the prevailing power that created silences during and post-dictatorship. The process of taking or 'creating' photographs incites power over memories. As Susan Sontag puts it, photography is a 'social rite, a defense against anxiety, and a tool of power' where the photographer intervenes documentation and situates himself and the subject in an 'image-world that bids to outlast us all'.[26] Besides the photographer's power to create tangible evidence of the past, the photographs' power over memories also lies on the various interpretations, functions and feelings they evoke. With the shifting underlying and perceived meanings in different temporalities, the activation of photographs should be continuously done as Eric Ketelaar writes, 'every interaction, intervention, interrogation, and interpretation by creator, user, and archivist is an activation of the record. The archive is an infinite activation of the record. Each activation leaves fingerprints which are attributes to the archive's infinite meaning'.[27] Activating these records from the margins by welcoming more voices and untold stories is one way of embracing the power and responsibility of archivists to create a democratic space. This space allows more nuanced discussions and understanding of the past, and progressive building of a better future.

Listening to the creation of photographs unravels rich stories and historical consciousness, as well as humanistic dimensions of archival theory and practice. Lito's photographs have disclosed one layer of silence and imaginary as they transcended the impossibility of creating evidence during a repressive time. These photographs that are not yet preserved in an archival repository may have achieved their original or primary purpose of documentation, but the other segments of realities captured within the frames remain to be sidelined – leaving questions such as, *Where are the photographs' subjects now? What were their thoughts and feelings then? How do they express and represent their own remembered experiences?* These additional layers of imaginaries are obviously missing and not being actively addressed by the traditional archival practices that are largely focused on data structures and limit the role of archivists in assembling contexts and meanings.[28] In activating photographs, the subjects must rightfully be treated as active participants or co-creators of the meaning and context

of records.[29] These unheard subjects, including Rodolfo, are some of the many individuals who are 'delinked from the bourgeois network' who continue to 'persist in creating their own history'.[30]

After a few months of searching and serendipitous encounters, I was lucky enough to meet Rodolfo and his wife, Celing. After hearing their stories, Celing said, *'Maraming salamat, anak, sa pakikinig'* [Thank you very much, my child, for listening]. This made me think further of the many absences and silences that are waiting to be discovered and heard.

Listening to the silences through photographs

In a democratic society, citizens vote and accord power to those who can and must speak for them. However, in political and democratic conversations, they often ignore listening.[31] While power is fundamentally associated with speaking and voicing one's authority, what has not been fully explored is the potential of listening as a political, and at the same time, a humanistic act in the performance of democracy and human rights. In embracing the power to mediate records and memories in uncovering silences, archivists can also use their power to listen as an act of bearing witness to the voices that have been previously denied. Photographs, more than being visual evidence, are deeply entangled with listening to oral stories for the articulation of histories.[32] As I intently listened to the stories of creation, co-creation and contextualisation of Lito's photographs, the participants were not treated as 'containers of information', but as important and empowered agents who could freely recall and let things be seen and understood in a new light.[33] I was also fully aware that talking about their past and revealing parts of themselves with a stranger could possibly cause anxiety and discomfort. As I was grappling with this ethical issue, I was drawn to Caswell's persuasive argument on the ethics of looking at violent images in her study of Tuol Sleng mugshots, that we can look at these photographs 'as long as such looking is properly contextualized'.[34] With that, I was more sensitive and tried not to ask a lot of questions to let them freely talk and reflexively situate themselves in the photographs and the contexts within which the photographs operate.

Lito shared his stories as a human rights worker turned part-time photographer. At the time of his arrest in 1974, Lito did not consider himself as an activist but rather a sympathiser. He was only a college student then and courier for his brother's underground newspaper, *Balita ng Malayang Pilipinas* (BMP or News from Free Philippines). His brother, top-ranking activist and co-founder of the National Democratic Front Philippines (NDFP) Satur Ocampo, started publishing BMP with the help of his wife and other activists. Lito delivered envelopes containing copies of BMP to other members of the underground movement, and some contacts in the government and media. Little did he know that working as a courier would lead him to jail for five years. Satur was also incarcerated in 1976.

Lito was released in 1979 and became a full-time activist helping the families of political detainees. He had seen and experienced the struggles of the imprisoned

activists and workers like Rodolfo. He joined KAPATID (*Kapisanan para sa Pagpapalaya ng mga Bilanggong Pulitikal sa Pilipinas* or Association for the Release and Amnesty of Detainees in the Philippines). They visited relatives and friends in prison, and campaigned for their release. Because the Marcos government publicly refused to admit military violence and unfair treatment of political prisoners, Lito, who simply wanted to work in the background, decided to produce evidence by smuggling in a camera even though he knew it was dangerous. This small camera, a half-frame one that doubled the shooting frame capacity of 35 mm film, was instrumental in his documentation of the life of the political detainees in Camp Bagong Diwa in Bicutan. Lito recounted:

> There was an assigned marketer, a wife of another detainee, who bought food and supplies and brought them inside the camp. So I handed the camera to her … and sometimes rolls of film whenever she would visit. She hid these underneath the vegetables or fruits. I would sometimes hide the film in my underwear, and we also handed some to female visitors … the guards weren't that strict with females.[35]

He continued to bring in rolls of films, which he would load into the camera away from view. He would stealthily take photos of the detainees and their activities inside. Once his visit was done, he would bring home the film, and carefully keep the camera inside the camp in Bicutan. He would then use the developed photographs in their mimeographed newsletter *Pahatid Kapatid*, where Lito was a one-man team that did all the production, mimeographing and distribution. His other important task was to release statements of the prisoners. Using the photographs that he secretly took, Lito made a stand and showed the side of the oppressed that was not usually seen and heard. While he was unsure of the actual reach of his photographs because of the difficulty of keeping and sending them to media outlets, he recalled,

> I gave those to Joe Burgos[36] (WE Forum and Malaya) and Joel Paredes (Malaya) for publication. I was even confronted by [authorities], they were baffled by the photos since they didn't see any cameras brought and used by me or the prisoners in Bicutan. The ones I turned over to Joel Paredes … [with] the one with 'We are Under Strike'. That came out, even carried by international papers. My shots and work were published internationally … that was still during the time of sending hard copies by mail. Or I would ask foreigners heading straight for Europe to hand-carry the hard copies.[37]

In one of his photographs, Rodolfo was the main subject, which provided a glimpse of the political prisoners' condition. It was taken during the prisoners' second week of fasting in 1982. Lito also went on hunger strike for four times when he was still detained. Even his own experiences were translated into the photographs he created. They were demanding not only freedom, but for more humane treatment and

better living conditions inside the prison. Looking at Rodolfo's portrait, the evidence of oppression is there. There may be no evident harassment or brutality, but the message is clear: detention cells are instruments of oppression and the political detainees' pleas deserve to be heard.

The stories of creation of these photographs that include the ways of inscription and transmission comprise a context-rich, reconceptualised provenance and continuous description of their origin.[38] The provenance of these photographs adds to a deeper understanding not only of the photographs themselves as tangible evidence, but the social conditions, people and forces that shape their production, circulation and meaning-making. Photographs operate not only as evidence, but also as sites of memory or *lieux de mémoire*. These are where memories and their interpretation take shape because the real events or environments are no longer present.[39] As sites of memory, photographs are loaded with meanings and various forms of affect. Affect is an important aspect of social justice work and aims that enables both contestations

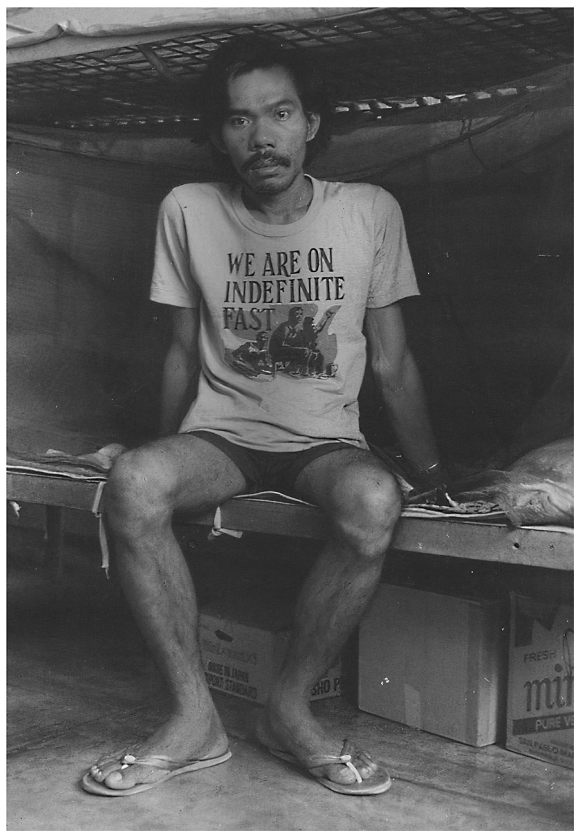


FIGURE 6.1 Rodolfo Benosa, 33 yrs old factory worker, solo breadwinner, married with 4 children. Shown here during their 2nd week of fasting-hunger strike in Bicutan last 1982. (Original caption by Lito Ocampo endorsed on photograph.)

and healing.[40] As people interact with photographs, life stories are evoked and generated so that the 'repressed or suppressed memories' not be completely forgotten or undermined by 'master memories' or dominant narratives.[41] Hence, photographs and the stories they unfold help empower those who have been usually neglected.

People looking at photographs would have different affective interactions with them. As Rodolfo and Celing looked at Lito's photograph, they described both the visible and not visible in the frames. They recalled their life back then – including the interrogation, torture and struggle that Rodolfo went through.

'This was inside Bicutan', said Rodolfo.

> The t-shirt I was wearing was printed by us, we did that for income, for fund raising. Students bought that shirt, the nuns also sold them. Noel Etabag, another political detainee who was with me in Bicutan, designed that shirt.[42]

Rodolfo remembered that it was Lito Ocampo who was photographing him and said, 'This one, that's where we slept', explained Rodolfo as he pointed to what appeared to be his bed. Rodolfo continued reminiscing,

> Underneath the *tarima* (a low bench or platform) were boxes of our clothes. During this moment, some prisoners covered themselves in blankets. They're lying down and hungry. We were fasting. Why? So, we would be set free. No charges were filed against us. We wanted all the workers freed. We fasted for some time. We lifted the fast near Christmas time. We ate small portions at night, we shouldn't die. If we did then the military would win. We wanted the international media and the world to be aware of our plight and that all political prisoners be freed.[43]

Rodolfo explained the cause of his engagement with the labour group, which was mainly rooted from longstanding labour problems such as unjust compensation and lack of benefits. Rodolfo thought that he was not doing anything subversive or unlawful because he just wanted the workers like him to provide for their families. He used to work in a factory run by Century Container Corporation as a seamer, the final step in sealing off cans. He worked there from 1962 until he was arrested and jailed in 1982. He was a founding member of the factory workers' independent labour union, separate from that of the company union, which he said was not fully worker-centred. 'I didn't just focus on our factory, I also visited other factories [during the union organization]', narrated Rodolfo.[44] He also recounted how little he was earning as a factory worker without any benefits. Rodolfo's wife, Celing, also described how the workers were mistreated,

> If they want to remove you they'll just fire you. If there's no valid reason they'll just make up some supposed problems so they can fire you. No SSS,[45] no overtime pay. They get minimum wage with no overtime pay. The company's owner was a Chinese businessman.[46]

When trying to remember the exact dates and names, Rodolfo and Celing used historical turning points like the opposition senator Ninoy Aquino's assassination in 1983 and Corazon Aquino's ascendancy to the presidency in 1986 as memory cues. This shows that individual memories tend to be shaped by emotionally charged events, such as personal experiences and significant historical events that are commemorated by the present society.[47] Celing tried to verify if Rodolfo's photograph was taken before or after Ninoy Aquino's assassination. But what Celing could openly recall was what happened on the night of Rodolfo's arrest in 1982 by the military who were wearing civilian clothes and without any identification. Rodolfo was blindfolded and his hands were bound with wire. She heard that there was also a crackdown on workers' movements in other factory areas like in Novaliches and Valenzuela. She barraged the military with questions, 'Where are you taking him [Rodolfo]? Who should I coordinate with? Who are you? Why don't you have name plates?' Their reply was consistent. No explanation was necessary because it was martial law.[48]

Rodolfo was held in different safe houses. Rodolfo remembered that he was held in Pasay, either at the Nichols Air Force Base (or Villamor Air Force Base), Transient Officers Quarters, Camp Crame, or at Camp Aguinaldo. Finally, he was transferred to the camp in Bicutan where he met Lito. He relived the torture he went through during tactical interrogation:

> One week … But that seemed like months. They tortured us day and night, no letting up. Different people would interrogate us. Police ... Military ... When they interrogate you they had guns. I can't really remember the exact time frames. They try to make you confess things you didn't do. If you don't confess or don't answer they'd beat you up. There was a time my interrogator snuffed out matchsticks and cigarettes in my mouth. What kind of people are these? All I was able to say was 'Sir, just get it over with and kill me. Just don't drag my family into this.' That's all I could think of. While I was in interrogation, I experienced a lot of pain. They tried to make me admit things.[49]

As they both looked at Lito Ocampo's photograph of Rodolfo, which they had not seen since 1993, Celing reassuringly said as she gave a cup of water to Rodolfo, 'Those were the days ... *Wala na 'yun, naninindak lang 'yun!* (They're gone, they were just terrifying you!)'[50] Celing and Rodolfo both ended up teary-eyed with the recollection of the tortures. 'It's hard. You have a family and you don't know what is happening to them', said Rodolfo, who was more concerned about his family than himself.[51]

These traumatic experiences left Rodolfo with nothing but desire to survive and secure the life and safety of his family. He continued to struggle with his family even after he was released in 1985. Rodolfo differentiated himself and his case from the other activists or political detainees,

> We're at the lowest rung. … Workers … We're only workers. Then they would arrest you and you would get jailed. You really lose your source of income. Your

> source of survival. It's not like being a teacher … Not like being able to finish your education … When they get released they could be gainfully employed again in their field. I think in my opinion it's quite different from us workers who have to be employed in factories.[52]

Rodolfo found it hard to return to their normal life after his release. Celing also felt that they were the most pitiful victims of martial law, as they lived a very difficult life even after the era had ended. She explained,

> It still [feels] fresh. That [seems to be] the consequence of what happened. No matter what we do, it doesn't go away. None of our kids finished their studies ... Not even one. It's so hard. He [Rodolfo] had to resign. He actually only got three thousand pesos in separation pay – that's from 1962-82. If you were in our place, you'd really have bad feelings / sentiments about it too. Look at us. We're already old. At our age, we still need to work to survive. We're not sure how long we could still put up with this. None of our kids finished their studies due to what we experienced. We're poor. It all boils down to the situation that started it all. That's the cause, right? We're really victims of martial law.[53]

I noticed that Rodolfo tended to be quiet and would occasionally speak and check some of his recollections with Celing. At 67 during the time of our conversation, Rodolfo had shown signs of failing health and memory. As Rodolfo was still recovering from a stroke, which I only found out during our meeting, I deeply apologised for starting a conversation that led to sad reminiscences. Celing shook her head and replied while smiling, '*Hindi, okay lang* (No, it's okay)'. Rodolfo also said, '*Okay lang* (It's okay)'. In remembering and confronting a distressing past, looking at photographs can also be recuperative.[54] It appeared that our conversation aided by photographs involves both reliving and relieving.

Rodolfo suggested that I should also speak with his fellow detainee and labour organiser, whom I also met at another time, as he could share more of his life stories and their experiences together. This shows that although they are not sharing the same physical space, looking at photographs while reminiscing is a social act that connects people in a community.[55] Their stories may or may not always follow the master narrative. But attention to these private or individual memories that are often disregarded in the dominant history, historical surveys and narratives is a political stance.[56] Compassionate listening while being ethically conscious and obligated to facilitate social justice work and purposes is therefore needed in envisioning an archives for the future.

Archives as a democratic space for the future

For many years, photography and the photographic medium itself have been used as powerful instruments to investigate issues and events, and to incite social change.[57] Photographs have been used as symbols and vital vehicles of persuasion by people's

movements in seeking sympathy, raising public awareness, and launching demonstrations to fight for freedom and rights. As various memory sites dedicated to the Marcos era have become battlegrounds for the complex and highly political work of representation and narration, more records, such as photographs, need to be discovered and activated. Lito's photographs from his personal collection, along with some other undiscovered records, have so much potential to be included in the archives as historical evidence and sites of memory. However, the power of inclusion in the archives also signals exclusion and silencing of other voices. This power to exclude, as Rodney Carter writes, 'is a fundamental aspect of the archive', where there are 'distortions, omissions, erasures, and silences … Not every story is told'.[58] Photographs may help fill in the gaps and silences of the past regime, but there will still be unheard voices of those who also fought, suffered and struggled to survive. Recognising both the power and limitation of archives is more constructive rather than staying under the pretence of neutrality and status quo. This limitation allows more opportunities and imaginaries to come in. Instead of seeing this limitation as a drawback, archivists should use this to envision an archives as a receptive space that is capable of welcoming more records, representations and voices from different individuals and communities. As a complete record of the past is difficult to actualise, Jacques Derrida underscores that 'the archivist produces more archive, and that is why the archive is never closed. It opens out of the future'.[59] Therefore, photographs as evidence and sites of memory do not necessarily complete or end an inquiry, but they help open a democratic space that engenders various affects and memories, initiates political and ethical engagements, and responds to the call of justice.

Acknowledging the silences is essential in envisioning archives as a democratic space. But what is more important is the realisation that not all silences are created equal – some will be uncovered and heard, some are quieter than the other silences, some choose to be still and unnoticed, and some may be forever missing and lost to oblivion. Archivists are encouraged to embrace their power to act as mediators in the collation of materials, facts and individual stories that would fill in the gaps and silences caused by inequalities and marginalisation. In a society where power ideally comes from the people but the power over official memory and narratives is only assigned to a few, listening plays a key role in equalising power relations.[60] By continuously activating photographs as records and sites of memory, archivists can help democratise access to memories and missing pieces of the past allowing various affective interactions between the records and participants. With the activation that combines listening and photographs together, archivists can perform powerful memory work as they transcend the past through the present to create a just future for the people.

Notes

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